THE POOL

An original fictional short

Story Factory demonstration

Inspired by the modest scale of early flight experiments, not by an actual musical event. All people, places, dialogue and events are invented. No historical person is represented.

FADE IN:

INT. EMPTY SWIMMING POOL - AFTERNOON

A drained municipal pool. Pale blue walls. JO, sixties, lowers a cello case down the shallow-end steps.

INEZ, also sixties, stands at the deep end with a pocket recorder.

INEZ

Say something.

JO

I’ve carried the cello down.

The room returns a soft, elongated cello down.

INEZ

Good.

JO

For whom?

Inez places the recorder on an upturned bucket. Jo opens the case. Inside, a yellow scarf cushions the instrument’s neck.

INEZ

Still got that.

JO

It’s a very reliable scarf.

Jo sits on a folding stool. Tunes a string. The room seems to listen.

Inez takes a small recorder from her pocket. The musical kind. She tests two notes, quietly. Jo looks up, surprised.

INEZ

For when I stop singing.

JO

Planning an emergency exit?

Inez puts it on the bucket, beside the other recorder.

INT. EMPTY SWIMMING POOL - MOMENTS LATER

Inez presses record. A small red light holds steady.

Jo begins a spare original phrase. Inez takes a breath to enter.

Nothing comes.

Jo finishes the phrase. Waits with her bow raised.

INEZ

Wrong note.

JO

Which one?

INEZ

The one I was going to sing.

Jo lowers the bow.

INEZ

Again.

They begin. Inez finds the first note. Her voice breaks on the second.

She reaches for the recorder. Jo sets her bow on her knees.

JO

I stopped playing. That’s on there too.

Inez takes her hand away from the recorder.

INEZ

It’s your last afternoon here. I’d like something decent.

JO

I’m moving. I’m not becoming a saint.

Inez looks up at the high windows. A little embarrassed by the size of the room she chose.

INEZ

It sounded better in my head.

JO

Most rooms do.

Jo sets the bow across her knees. She waits without offering another beginning.

INT. EMPTY SWIMMING POOL - LATER

Inez plays back the recording. Cello. A breath. A fractured note. Silence.

Then Jo’s voice, thin through the speaker.

JO (RECORDED)

I stopped playing. That’s on there too.

Inez stops the playback. Jo folds the yellow scarf, slowly.

INEZ

You could stay for the singing on Thursdays.

JO

And leave again every Friday?

Inez nods. She already knows.

Jo places the scarf back in the case.

INEZ

I don’t know who starts us without you.

JO

You do.

Inez looks at the little wind instrument. Picks it up. Turns it once between her palms.

Then puts it away.

She moves the recording bucket closer to the stool. No longer tries to put the whole pool between them.

INEZ

Don’t stop when I do that.

JO

When you do what?

INEZ

You know.

Jo lifts the bow.

INT. EMPTY SWIMMING POOL - CONTINUOUS

Inez presses record.

Jo begins the phrase again. Inez enters. The note catches. Jo keeps playing.

Inez holds the rough edge instead of fleeing it. Finds the next note. Jo changes her bow’s pressure to meet the smaller voice.

A short duet. Neither woman looks toward the recorder.

Their final sound goes up the pale blue walls and comes back changed.

Inez lets the room finish before she presses stop.

Jo sets the cello in its case. This time Inez helps, holding the scarf away from the closing lid.

INEZ

May I play that on Thursday?

Jo nods.

JO

Use both names.

Inez presses record again and raises the recorder to her mouth.

INEZ

Jo and Inez. In the pool.

She stops recording. Almost adds an explanation. Doesn’t.

Jo offers one end of the heavy case. Inez takes it. They carry it together toward the steps.

The empty bucket stays at the deep end.

FADE OUT.

THE END